

Vought F4U Corsair



“It got to be a very fine plane once the bugs were out of it.”

HERBERT D. RILEY
ADMIRAL, US NAVY

THE F4U CORSAIR is regarded by some as the best carrier-borne fighter of WWII. In some ways it was ingeniously designed for service at sea. Take for example the striking “inverted gull” wing shape. This allowed the designers to make the undercarriage, placed at the lowest point of the wing, short and sturdy – ideal for carrier landing, while still keeping the very large propeller clear of the deck. Yet in other ways



ROCKETS ABOARD
These servicemen in Okinawa are loading the underwing of a Corsair with 5in rockets, June 1945.

the Corsair was unsuited for carrier service. When the first Corsairs were delivered to the US Navy in October 1942, pilots found that with the long engine stretching in front of them, they had to lean out of the side of the cockpit to see where they were going. This proved especially problematic when attempting to land on a carrier deck, which became an extremely hazardous procedure. Consequently, the Corsair was first deployed operationally in 1943 with shore-based squadrons (mostly US Marines) in the Pacific. The aircraft was not cleared for

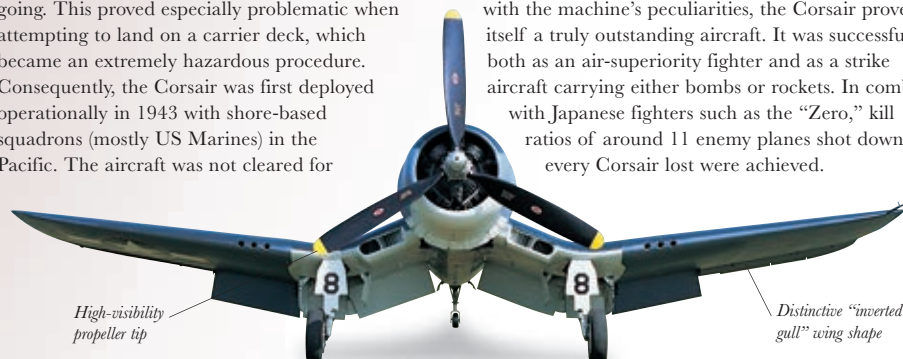


INTO ACTION

Fighter pilots in the Solomon Islands rush from a “ready room” to their waiting airplanes. Corsairs were flown by the US Marines (shown here), the US Navy, and Britain’s Fleet Air Arm. They remained in service until the 1950s.

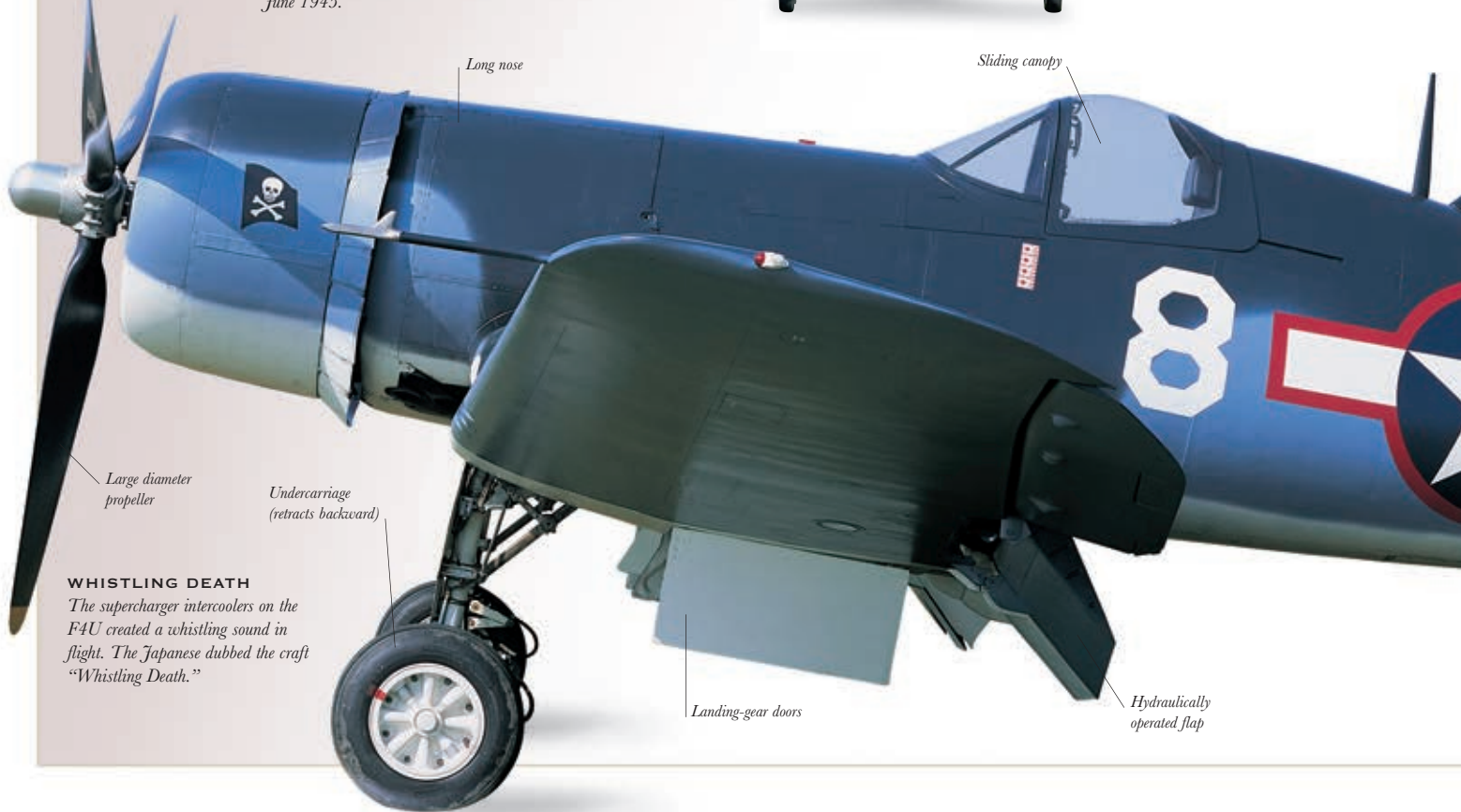
carrier service until April 1944, by which time the pilot’s seat and cockpit canopy had been raised to improve visibility.

Once this and a number of other adjustments had been made and pilots had learned how to cope with the machine’s peculiarities, the Corsair proved itself a truly outstanding aircraft. It was successful both as an air-superiority fighter and as a strike aircraft carrying either bombs or rockets. In combat with Japanese fighters such as the “Zero,” kill ratios of around 11 enemy planes shot down to every Corsair lost were achieved.



High-visibility propeller tip

Distinctive “inverted gull” wing shape



Long nose

Sliding canopy

Large diameter propeller

Undercarriage (retracts backward)

Landing-gear doors

Hydraulically operated flap

WHISTLING DEATH

The supercharger intercoolers on the F4U created a whistling sound in flight. The Japanese dubbed the craft “Whistling Death.”